Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A Q J 10 9 8
♥ A Q J
♦ 8 4
♣ A Q

♠ K 7 2
♥ K 9 6 4
♦ 9 2
♣ K 7 6 3

♠ 6 5
♥ 10 8 3
♦ K Q J 10 7
♣ 8 4 2

♠ 4 3
♥ 7 5 2
♦ A 6 5 3
♣ J 10 9 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦K

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦K.

West plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

East has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that East has led from ♦ K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't.

East continues with the ♦Q.

You take it with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one?

West plays low.

At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 8 7 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A Q J 10	
♠ 10 2 ♥ K Q J 5 2 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3	N W E S	♠ — ♥ 10 8 7 3 ♦ K J 9 4 ♣ K 8 6 5 2
	♠ K Q J 9 6 5 4 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 5 2 ♣ 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥6 and East the ♥3.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 3

Your only hope for ridding yourself of two of those losers is dummy's ♣ suit. One possibility would be to finesse West for the ♣K, and if that works, discard your ♥ loser on the ♣A. You could then establish another ♣ winner for one of the ♦ losers. The problem with that plan is that if the finesse fails the defense will immediately take the setting ♥ trick.

A better plan is a ruffing finesse. Win the first trick with your ♥A and pull trumps with your ♠ K Q.

West plays low.

Your ♣7 to dummy's ♣A.

The ♣Q from dummy: a ruffing finesse. If East plays the ♣K you will ruff, enter dummy, and discard two red losers on the ♣ J 10. If East plays low instead, you discard your ♥ loser. West may be able to win the trick but you can ruff a ♥ return, and dummy will have two good ♣s on which you can discard 2 ♦ losers.

Ruffing finesses sometimes provide you the best opportunity, like this time.

But they are easy to overlook, mainly because we don't use them often.

Board 3
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2	
♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 8 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3	N W E S	♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4
	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♦	Pass
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦K

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and West the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If West has the ♠K you can finesse him out of it. Or, you have a two-way finesse for the ♥Q.

It is an easy choice. The defenders only have 12 HCP and East opened the bidding. So you know he must have both of the cards you are interested in.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

East continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and West the ♦8.

East continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and West discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round just to be safe.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

East covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If East doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But East does cover so you take dummy's ♥A, then your other 2 ♥ tricks. The ♠A is your ninth trick.

You might think that a two-way finesse offers you a 50% chance of guessing correctly.

Sometimes that may be right. But there are other times when information from the bidding or the opening lead allows you to make a higher-percentage guess.

Board 4
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 7 4 ♥ 10 9 6 ♦ Q 5 ♣ A K 8 2	
♠ K 2 ♥ K J 8 5 ♦ J 8 7 4 ♣ 10 6 3		♠ 10 9 8 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 10 9 6 3 2 ♣ 9 7
	♠ Q 6 5 3 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ A K ♣ Q J 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♥5

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♥5. The defense wins 3 ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 3 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 ?

You have already lost the 3 ♥ tricks so you must pick up the trump suit without loss.

West plays low.

The odds aren't in your favor, but you have no choice but to play West for the doubleton King.

So: a small ♠ from your hand, putting on the ♠J when West plays low. When this holds the trick plunk down the ♠A and hope.

This position is one that is misplayed very often.

Look what would have occurred if you had started with the ♠Q. West would have covered with the ♠K (if he had it) and you would have lost a trick to the ♠10 later.

The only hope is to try to drop the ♠K without wasting an extra honor.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A ♥ K J 9 8 7 4 2 ♦ Q J ♣ A J 10	
♠ K 10 5 4 3 ♥ 6 ♦ 8 3 2 ♣ K 9 7 4	N W E S	♠ Q J 9 7 ♥ 10 5 3 ♦ A K 10 6 ♣ Q 6
	♠ 8 6 2 ♥ A Q ♦ 9 7 5 4 ♣ 8 5 3 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♥	Pass	1NT
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♦A

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♦A. The defenders take two ♦ tricks, then switch to a trump.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 4

The status is pretty clear, you've already lost the 2 ♦s so you have to keep your ♣ losers to just one. You have a good chance of pulling that off by playing for the ♣K and ♣Q to lie in different hands and taking two finesses.

West plays low.

You will only be in dummy once more, so you **MUST** make the first finesse right now: a small ♣ from dummy to your ♣10 (or ♣J). East wins with the ♣Q and plays another trump.

East leads the ♥5.

In dummy for the last time you must now take your second ♣ finesse.

West plays low.

A small ♣ to your remaining honour. When the ♣J wins you pull any leftover trumps and your hand is good.

This Deal is an excellent example of how and when to use the Double-Finesse, which gives you a 75% chance of success.

It was probably a better example of watching your entries. If you had pulled another trump before taking that first ♣ finesse you would not have been able to take the second one.